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The Mood Survey: A Personality Measure of Happy and Sad Moods

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Abstract: It was suggested that while moods clearly are subject to tremendous variation, there may nonetheless be some utility in considering long-term differences in mood, that is, in treating mood as a personality characteristic. People who are characteristically at different points of a mood dimension may show real differences in behavior that are not totally obscured by short-term mood variation. This approach may also facilitate the investigation of components of mood other than level, which is the focus of most state mood questionnaires. A personality instrument for happy and sad moods, the Mood Survey, was factor-analyzed and found to have two primary subscales: Level and Reactivity. These intercorrelated subscales were shown to have consistent advantages over a state measure of mood both in predicting personality characteristics and in pointing to new hypotheses about the nature of mood.

Most recent work with mood, with a few notable exceptions (e.g., Wessman & Ricks, 1966), has involved the manipulation of situational variables in order to produce short-term changes in mood. In some cases the manipulation has focused directly on mood (Moore, Underwood, & Rosenhan, 1973), while in other cases mood change has been an indirect byproduct of some other experience such as success or failure (Berkowitz & Connor, 1966). Whatever the nature of the manipulation, however, mood has usually been regarded as a transient phenomenon. Consequently, tests of mood have generally been state measures rather than trait measures. While we recognize that there are certain advantages in such state measures (c.f., Nowlis, 1965), we must also recognize that a state measure is inadequate for investigating certain aspects of mood.

For example, while we admit that moods vary tremendously, often over very short periods of time, we maintain that there are some people who are typically very happy and others who can be very generally characterized as sad. Thus the average level of mood for two such people might differ dramatically, regardless of the short-term variations which might obscure these differences in average mood level. It may prove useful to identify people who differ in average mood level taken over a long period of time—that is, in typical mood

level. Such differences would be difficult to assess by state measures since they would require a very long period of data collection. We have attempted to construct a measure of typical mood so as to facilitate such an assessment. Measuring a person's typical mood may offer several advantages. First, it provides a basis for examining the person component of the person-situation interaction. This seems likely to prove useful both theoretically and empirically. Second, measures of typical mood may actually provide better predictability in some circumstances than do measures of current mood. If mood were a causal influence on a certain behavior, then state measures of mood would be more appropriate since short-term fluctuation in mood would predict changes in behavior. However, if mood and behavior are related noncausally, then short-term mood fluctuations would not be especially useful since they would not predict changes in the behavior. In this case, a measure of typical mood level which minimizes the effect of short-term variability might be more strongly related to the behavioral measures. Recent evidence (Underwood, Froming, & Moore, in press) suggests that mood is not the causal factor in the frequently obtained correlational relationship with personality measures, since personality scores do not vary as a result of mood manipulations. Thus a measure of typical or

trait mood might prove to be especially useful for detecting relationships between mood and personality.

In constructing this trait measure of mood, the decision was made to concentrate on one type of mood, the happy-sad dimension. While other mood states surely exist, researchers and theorists seem to agree that the happy-sad dimension is a central mood state (e.g., Wessman & Ricks, 1966). Thus, it seemed a suitable arena for examining individual differences in mood. We have also decided to treat happy and sad as endpoints on a continuum, since we know of no evidence which argues persuasively for keeping the two aspects separate.

In devising any new measure one needs to consider the dimensions which should be measured. Initially these dimensions are entirely conceptual rather than empirical. Three dimensions of mood emerged from our conceptual analysis. The first was the average *level* of a person's mood. Some individuals appear to be always cheerful, happy and generally "up." In contrast, others seem very somber and unhappy. Questions were therefore constructed which would measure an individual's general mood level. A second dimension was thought to be the *intensity* with which a person reacted to any particular mood experience. Some individuals respond with mild good humor to happy experiences while others approach the heights of elation and euphoria. On the negative end some individuals become only mildly unhappy after unpleasant experiences whereas others may plunge to the depths of despair. To examine this aspect of mood, questions were designed to measure intensity of mood reactions. The third and final dimension which our measure incorporated was a gauge of the *frequency* of mood experiences. Certain individuals report several mood experiences each day so that their mood states are continually changing. In contrast, other people have mood shifts only now and again (i.e., a few times a week). To distinguish between these two extremes we designed

questions to examine how frequently people shifted mood states.

The rest of this paper details the factor analyses and validity and reliability data which we have gathered using a trait measure of mood, the Mood Survey. These data will establish the psychometric basis for the instrument as well as providing empirical grounds on which to judge the relative benefits of state and trait measures.

STUDY I

Method

Subjects

Subjects were 231 female and 171 male students in an introductory psychology course at the University of Texas at Austin.

Procedure

The questionnaire consisted of 34 items intended to describe general level of mood, frequency of mood changes, and intensity of reaction to mood-altering events. Subjects were asked to indicate degree of agreement with each statement on a six-point scale ranging from "strongly agree" to "strongly disagree" and were urged "to consider ... usual or general behavior" in arriving at a response. The questionnaire was administered to all subjects during a single regularly scheduled class hour.

Results

Responses to the questionnaire were subjected to a factor analysis, using principal components factor extraction and Varimax rotation. Using a criterion of accounting for at least 10% of the total variance, only two of the factors which emerged from this analysis could be considered major factors. The first, which accounted for 30% of the variance, consisted of items describing mood level. The second, which accounted for 13% of the variance, consisted of items describing a general reactivity to mood-relevant events, with most of the items being related to frequency of mood changes. Items with a factor loading above .40 on either of these factors are listed in Table 1, along

Table 1
Factor Loadings for the Two Primary Factors

	Level	Reactivity
1. I may change from happy to sad and back again several times in a single week.	-.12	+.72
2. I'm frequently "down in the dumps."	-.35	+.46
3. Compared to my friends I'm less up and down in my mood states.	.15	-.48
4. I usually feel quite cheerful.	.72	-.20
5. I generally look at the sunny side of life.	.67	-.20
6. I'm not often really elated.	-.57	+.09
7. I usually feel as though I'm bubbling over with joy.	.70	-.09
8. Sometimes my moods swing back and forth very rapidly.	-.10	+.65
9. Sometimes even very minor events can make me really elated.	.40	+.18
10. My moods are quite consistent; they almost never vary.	.16	-.60
11. Compared to my friends, I think less positively about life in general.	-.60	.17
12. I'm a very changeable person.	-.08	.49
13. I am not as cheerful as most people.	-.69	.08
14. I'm not as "moody" as most people I know.	.13	-.41
15. My friends often seem to feel I am unhappy.	-.46	.18
16. I consider myself a happy person.	.67	-.15

with their loadings on both factors. It was decided to drop item 9 from the Level factor since its loading was near the minimum acceptable and it had a loading of nearly the same magnitude on a minor factor. The remaining 15 items were unit-weighted (weighted +1 if the factor loading was above +.40, and -1 if the loading was below -.40) to form a Level and a Reactivity subscale. The correlation between the two subscales was $-.45$ ($df = 400$, $p < .001$). Females described themselves as significantly more reactive than males ($r_{pb} = .22$, $df = 400$, $p < .001$) but there was no significant sex difference on mood level ($r_{pb} = .05$, $df = 400$, $p > .10$).

Discussion

The results are not precisely as anticipated in at least two regards. First, there is a fairly substantial negative correlation between the Level and Reactivity subscales which emerged from the factor analysis. There are two possible explanations for this. The first maintains that the two subscales are measuring essentially the same thing. Thus there is a significant correlation between the two, and one should expect to find a highly similar pattern of correlations with other measures for the two sub-

scales. The second explanation suggests that the two subscales are conceptually distinct but merely happen to be related. It may be, for example, that very reactive people are somewhat sadder partly *because* they are more reactive. Having one's affects constantly buffeted about by a capricious environment may be a rather unpleasant experience, thus making such people less happy than people who aren't so reactive. The basis for choosing between these two explanations must be through an analysis of the discriminant validity of the two scales. If the subscales provide redundant information, always being related in the same way to the same measures, then we should conclude that this first explanation is correct. If they should prove to be related to different measures, however, then we should conclude that the second explanation is correct. There is obviously no information in the current study upon which to base this decision, but we shall return to this question later.

Additionally, the factor structure is somewhat different from the anticipated one, since there is a single Reactivity subscale rather than separate frequency and intensity subscales. There is, however, a certain reasonableness to

Table 2
Factor Loadings

	Level	Reactivity
1. I may change from happy to sad and back again several times in a single week.	-.14	.76
2. I usually feel quite cheerful.	.71	-.08
3. I'm frequently "down in the dumps."	-.42	.42
4. I generally look at the sunny side of life.	.65	-.12
5. Compared to my friends, I'm less up and down in my mood states.	.19	-.31
6. I'm not often really elated.	-.43	-.03
7. Sometimes my moods swing back and forth very rapidly.	-.11	.71
8. I usually feel as though I'm bubbling over with joy.	.56	-.05
9. My moods are quite consistent; they almost never vary.	.06	-.69
10. I consider myself a happy person.	.75	-.10
11. Compared to my friends, I think less positively about life in general.	-.62	.11
12. I'm a very changeable person.	-.10	.51
13. I am not as cheerful as most people.	-.63	.16
14. I'm not as "moody" as most people I know.	.15	-.43
15. My friends often seem to feel I am unhappy.	-.52	.19
16. If 1 = extremely sad, 50 = neutral, and 99 = extremely happy, how happy are you in general?	.69	-.12
17. If 1 = hardly ever and 99 = extremely frequently, how frequently do your moods change?	-.13	.77
18. If 1 = not at all and 99 = extremely intensely, how intensely do you react to mood experiences?	-.04	.52

the existence of a general Reactivity factor. The explanation may be that the range of events which produce a perceived mood change extends further toward the mildly affective end of the dimension for people who show intense reactions to mood-inducing stimuli. The result may be that they are likely to experience mood changes more frequently than less intense reactors because there are a greater number of events capable of producing such changes. According to this view, separate factors for frequency and intensity do not emerge because these two characteristics are intrinsically correlated. The reactivity factor, then, may be thought of as reflecting both frequency and intensity judgments.

In order to partially test this explanation, a shorter version of the questionnaire was constructed and titled the Mood Survey. In addition to the seven items of the Reactivity subscale and the eight items (omitting item #9) of the Level subscale, there were three additional items asking subjects to estimate (using a 99-point scale) their mood level,

frequency of mood change, and intensity of mood reactions. It was expected that both the frequency and the intensity item would load on the Reactivity factor and that both items would be highly correlated with that factor, supporting the notion that the Reactivity factor reflects the mutual influence of the two intrinsically correlated components—frequency and intensity—of mood reactions.

STUDY II

Method

Subjects were 265 female and 157 male students in an introductory psychology course at the University of Texas at Austin. The subjects were given the Mood Survey during a single regularly scheduled class session.

Results

Responses to the 18 items of the Mood Survey were subjected to a factor analysis, using principal components factor extraction and Varimax rotation. Using a criterion of accounting for at

Table 3
Correlations of
New Items with Original Factors

Factor	Item		
	Level	Frequency	Intensity
Level	.64**	-.26**	-.13*
Reactivity	-.28**	.72**	.44**

* $p < .01$.

** $p < .001$.

least 10% of the total variance, there were two major factors among those which emerged from the analysis. The factor loadings for the two factors are listed in Table 2. Correlations between each of the three new items and the two original subscales are shown in Table 3. Once more there was a significant sex difference on the Reactivity ($r_{pb} = .19$, $df = 420$, $p < .001$) but not on the Level ($r_{pb} = .05$, $df = 420$, $p > .30$) subscale, with females scoring higher on Reactivity, and the subscales were significantly correlated ($r = -.36$, $df = 420$, $p < .001$).

Discussion

The results of the prior factor analysis have been almost exactly replicated. The failure of item five to achieve the .40 criterion for factor loading in this analysis may be illuminated by considering a minor third factor which emerged in this analysis. The only two items which had a factor loading above .40 on this third factor were items five and fourteen, which are the only two items on the Reactivity scale which call for a social comparison. Thus we might think of three factors as having emerged from this analysis (although the third factor accounted for only 6% of the variance): Level, Reactivity (judged by internal standards), and Reactivity (judged by social comparison). Given the similarity of content in the latter two factors, we are inclined to suggest that they continue to be combined into a single Reactivity factor.

The results for the three added items are in accord with expectations. While each of the three correlated significantly with both Level and Reactivity sub-

scales (perhaps not unexpectedly given the modest correlation between Level and Reactivity), the Level item correlated significantly more highly with the Level than with the Reactivity subscale while the Frequency and Intensity items both correlated significantly more highly with the Reactivity than with the Level subscale ($p < .001$ in all three cases).

The previous data would seem to establish a consistent and meaningful factor structure for the Mood Survey, so the next question concerns reliability. In order for the distinction between trait and state measures of mood to be valid in comparing the Mood Survey with state measures, there must be some evidence that what is being measured by this instrument is, in fact, trait mood. One such bit of evidence would be a substantial test-retest reliability, which would contrast with the rather modest test-retest reliabilities which have been obtained with state measures of mood (e.g., Nowlis, 1965; Ryman, Biersner, & La Rocca, 1974). The greater test-retest reliability would point to greater stability over time, which is one of the defining differences between a trait and a state.

STUDY III

Method

The Mood Survey was administered to 89 female and 45 male students in introductory psychology classes at the University of Texas at Austin. Three weeks later, 48 female and 25 male students filled out the survey a second time during class hours. Seven weeks after the initial administration, a group consisting of the remaining 41 females and 20 males filled out the survey a second time, but this time outside class hours.

Results and Discussion

The test-retest reliabilities for both Level and Reactivity subscales are given in Table 4. The reliability for the three-week period is strikingly high for both scales. This high reliability is maintained over the seven-week period for

Table 4

Test-retest Reliabilities for the Mood Survey

Subscale	Time Elapsed Between Tests	
	3 Weeks	7 Weeks
Level	.80	.63
Reactivity	.85	.83

Note: $p < .001$ in all cases.

Reactivity while it declines somewhat for Level, although it is nonetheless higher than the figures typically reported for state measure of mood level. This establishes one aspect of the anticipated superiority of the trait measure, namely that there should be better predictability over long periods of time because the predictor score is less likely to have undergone dramatic change. Adequate reliability, however, is only an initial test of utility. The second stage is the demonstration of concurrent validity, i.e., that the subscales should show significant correlations with other instruments purporting to measure similar constructs. With this in mind, a study was conducted in which subjects were given the Mood Survey; the Mood Adjective Checklist (MACL), a commonly used state measure of mood level (Nowlis, 1965); and the EASI temperament survey (Buss & Plomin, 1975), which contains Emotionality, Activity level, Sociability, and Impulsivity subscales. It was hypothesized that the Level subscale of the Mood Survey would correlate significantly with the Happy, Sad, and Mood (Happy minus Sad) subscales of the MACL but that the Reactivity subscale would not, or would do so to a lesser degree. It was further hypothesized that the Reactivity subscale would correlate significantly

with the Emotionality subscale of the EASI but that the Level subscale would not, or would do so to a lesser degree. This pattern of correlations would establish not only the concurrent validity of the Mood Survey subscales, but discriminant validity as well. Finally, it was hypothesized that the Level subscale would correlate significantly with the Sociability subscale of the EASI since this personality dimension has frequently been found to be related to state mood level.

STUDY IV

Method

The Mood Survey, MACL, and EASI were given to 19 female and 57 male introductory psychology students at the University of Texas at Austin. Another 24 female and 24 male students were given only the Mood Survey and the MACL.

Results and Discussion

The correlations between Mood Survey subscales and the other instruments are given in Table 5. The results are, for the most part, as hypothesized. The only real departures from expectations are the significant and near-significant correlations between Reactivity and the MACL subscales. In all three cases, however, the correlation with Level is larger than that with Reactivity. Because the modest correlation between Level and Reactivity subscales ($r = -.37$, $df = 122$, $p < .001$, in this sample) clouds the meaning of correlations with both subscales, partial correlations were computed for each subscale while controlling for the other.

Table 5
Validity Correlations for Mood Survey Subscales

	Happy	Sad	Mood	Emotion- ality	Activity Level	Sociability	Impulsivity
Level	.32***	-.30**	.41***	-.09	.23	.39***	.06
Reactivity	-.15	.20*	-.24**	.69***	.08	.13	.24*

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

*** $p < .001$.

Table 6
Partial Correlations

	Happy	Sad	Mood
Level	.29**	-.25*	.36**
Reactivity	-.04	.10	-.10

* $p < .01$.

** $p < .001$.

These correlations are listed in Table 6. As can be seen from this table, the significant correlations between Level and MACL subscales remain even after the influence of Reactivity has been removed. Any trace of a significant correlation between Reactivity and MACL subscales, however, disappears when the influence of Level is removed. The nature of the correlation between Reactivity and Level seems somewhat clearer given these results. The two subscales cannot be asserted to be highly similar in light of the very different pattern of correlations with EASI subscales (see Table 5) and of partial correlations with MACL subscales (see Table 6). Rather, they are clearly measuring conceptually distinct constructs which happen to be somewhat related, perhaps for reasons we have already suggested.

In fact, the correlations with EASI subscales suggest a model for correlations with the level and reactivity dimensions of mood, as measured by the Mood Survey. Reactivity correlated significantly with both the temperaments which involve some sort of *reaction* to a stimulus situation: emotionality and impulsivity. Mood level, on the other hand, was correlated only with those temperaments which are not reactive, significantly with sociability and nearly significant ($p < .06$) with activity level. The correlations with activity level and impulsivity are admittedly small, and may not prove to be reliable, but this pattern suggests that we might expect mood reactivity to be related to other reactive dimensions and mood level to be related only to non-reactive dimensions.

Parenthetically, it should be recalled that small but significant sex differences

have emerged consistently on the reactivity subscale. Thus it was deemed necessary to analyze the data separately for males and females in studies IV, V, and VI. The pattern and size of the obtained correlations proved to be virtually identical. For ease of presentation it was therefore decided to discuss only the data from the analyses which pooled the two sexes.

We have now established reliability, concurrent validity, and discriminant validity for the Level and Reactivity subscales of the Mood Survey. This establishes the Mood Survey as a potentially useful inventory and suggests at least one advantage it has over state measures of mood—increased stability over time. The true test of utility for a new measure, however, is the demonstration that it does some job better than existing measures. In this case, the job to be performed is the prediction of personality test scores from mood scores. One's ranking on personality dimensions must be the result of an accumulation of life experiences over many years. Because of this, one might expect such measures to be more strongly related to a mood measure which itself reflects the accumulated experience of a lifetime than to one which measures only the current, transient mood state. Thus we expect that a trait measure of mood will be more strongly related to personality variables than will a state measure of mood. In order to test this, Mood Survey subscales and MACL subscales may be correlated with personality measures. The hypothesis is that the Level subscale will correlate more highly with personality measures than will the MACL subscales which measure state mood level. It is further hypothesized that the Reactivity subscale will show a predictive advantage for those measures which are reactive. In the study to be described, there is one such measure. It is a measure of variability (Olsson, Note 1) which notes simply whether the person's behavior varies much from one situation to another (i.e., to what extent the person is differentially reactive to different situa-

tions). It is felt that this measure will be related more strongly to mood reactivity than to mood level due to its status as a measure of reactivity or changeability.

STUDY V

Method

Subjects

Subjects were 132 male and 131 female students in introductory psychology courses at the University of Texas at Austin.

Procedure

The Mood Survey, the Mood Adjective Checklist, the Alienation Scale (Dean, 1961), the Janis-Field Feelings of Inadequacy Scale (Eagly, 1967), and the Internal-External Locus of Control Scale (Rotter, 1966) were given to 48 male and 48 female subjects in groups of four. The Mood Survey, the Mood Adjective Checklist, the Self-conscious-

ness Inventory (Fenigstein, Scheier, & Buss, 1975), and the Self-description Survey (Olsson, Note 1) were given to 48 male and 47 female subjects in small groups ranging in size from three to six. The Mood Survey and the Mood Adjective Checklist were given individually to another 36 male and 36 female subjects. The Alienation Scale contains three subscales: normlessness, powerlessness, and social isolation. The Self-consciousness Inventory has three subscales: public self-consciousness, private self-consciousness, and social anxiety. The Self-description Survey has four subscales: social involvement, affiliativeness, warmth, and variability. For this study the Janis-Field Feelings of Inadequacy Scale was divided into three subscales: achievement self-esteem (e.g., How often do you have the feeling that you can do everything well?), social self-esteem (e.g., How often are you troubled with shyness?), and general self-esteem (e.g., How often do you feel inferior to most of the people you know?).

Results and Discussion

The pattern of mood-personality correlations is given in Table 7. Of the ten personality measures with which the Level subscale of the Mood Survey correlated significantly, it also correlated more strongly than the mood subscale of the MACL with all ten ($p < .001$ by the sign test). In addition, tests of the difference between correlation coefficients (Glass & Stanley, 1970) revealed that the mood level subscale is correlated significantly more strongly than the mood subscale of the MACL with Affiliativeness ($p < .001$) and Warmth ($p < .025$), and nearly so with Social Isolation ($p < .08$) and Social Anxiety ($p < .09$). This established the expected superiority of the trait mood measure in concurrent prediction of personality measures. When combined with previously discussed superiority in stability over time, this paints a very favorable picture of the advantages of a trait measure of mood level.

We should emphasize, however, that

Table 7
Mood-Personality Correlations

Personality Dimension	Mood Level	Mood Scale	
		Mood Survey Level	Mood Survey Reactivity
Locus of control	.21*	.30**	-.36**
Normlessness	-.33**	-.35**	.38**
Powerlessness	-.21*	-.26**	.38**
Social isolation	-.20*	-.37**	.35**
Achievement self-esteem	.45**	.46**	-.38**
Social self-esteem	.26*	.37**	-.15
General self-esteem	.38**	.48**	-.43**
Affiliativeness	.33**	.63**	-.29**
Social involvement	.31**	.46**	-.29**
Warmth	.40**	.60**	-.39**
Variability	-.19	-.13	.29**
Social anxiety	-.23*	-.39**	.36**
Private self-consciousness	-.02	-.16	.24*
Public self-consciousness	-.08	-.03	.20

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

we are not proposing to replace state measures with trait measures in all settings. There are many cases in which state measures will be more appropriate than trait measures. Their sensitivity to change means that they will be better suited than trait measures to any situation involving the assessment of short-term variation, such as a documentation of patterns of mood variation in response to life circumstances or a check on the effectiveness of an attempted experimental manipulation of mood. What we are suggesting is simply that there are also times when a trait measure of mood will be more useful, such as detecting relationships with personality variables.

Another possible occasion in which a trait measure such as the Mood Survey will be more appropriate is any situation in which information involving mood reactivity is needed. State measures do not include such information, possibly because it does not readily adapt to the "answer as you feel right now" instructions which typify state measures. One possible use for reactivity information is in subject selection for experiments. Experimental manipulations of mood must be relatively mild, for obvious ethical reasons. In order to maximize the chances for an experimental manipulation to have an influence, and thus provide an adequate test of one's experimental hypothesis, an experimenter could select subjects high on the reactivity scale. These subjects would be most likely to show the influence of the manipulation, since they tend to react to even mildly mood-inducing experiences.

Reactivity information is potentially useful not only for subject selection, however, but for clarifying the nature of certain mood-personality relationships as well. The link between certain personality characteristics and mood may be through reactivity, either in addition to or instead of through mood level. We have already noted that for certain dimensions (emotionality, impulsivity, variability, and public and private self-consciousness), the mood

reactivity subscale is a significant or near-significant predictor while the mood level subscale is not. For several other personality variables in Study V, reactivity and level are both significant predictors (see Table 7).

The pattern of correlations with level and reactivity is interesting and suggestive. Most of these personality dimensions which are significantly correlated with both subscales have a pole which can be thought of as representing extreme negative feelings. Self-esteem and alienation are obviously such dimensions, and it is likely that such a characterization would fit locus of control as well. A person with extreme external locus of control feels unable to control his or her own life circumstances, which would seem to involve negative feelings. In addition, depressives have been found to be characterized by an external locus of control (Naditch, Gargan, & Michael, 1975) which would seem to suggest that external locus of control is accompanied by very negative feelings. In most of these cases, reactivity is not only significantly correlated with the personality dimension but is correlated roughly as strongly as is mood level (see Table 7).

For dimensions involving sociability and activity level, however, where neither end is likely to be associated with extremely negative feelings, reactivity is either not significantly correlated with the dimension (sociability and activity level; see Table 5) or correlated notably less strongly than is mood level (affiliativeness, social involvement, warmth; see Table 7). There are only two exceptions to this pattern. One is social self-esteem, which is a self-esteem measure but looks more like the sociability dimensions in its relation to Mood Survey subscales, since it is correlated significantly with the Level but not the Reactivity subscale. The other exception is social anxiety, which was included with sociability measures but looks more like the dimensions involving negative feelings in its relation to the Mood Survey, since it is correlated about equally strongly with both Mood

Survey subscales. In both cases there seems to be a sort of hybrid mixture of sociability and potential for negative feeling which may explain the pattern reversal.

This pattern is suggestive of a certain type of relation between depression and the Mood Survey. It suggests that depression may be as much a phenomenon of mood reactivity as of mood level. This would make a great deal of sense, at least for certain types of depression which may be characterized as a reaction to negative life circumstances. Indeed, any episode of depression may be thought of as involving a mood swing which drops below some threshold level. People who are characteristically near this threshold in mood level would be more likely to cross it eventually, but so would people with greater reactivity since they would have more frequent and larger mood swings. This suggests that accepted measures of depression might well show significant correlations with both subscales of the Mood Survey, which was the object of Study IV.

STUDY VI

Method

Subjects

Subjects were 61 female and 29 male students in an introductory psychology course at the University of Texas at Austin.

Procedure

The Mood Survey and the Beck Depression Inventory (BDI; Beck, 1967) were given to the subjects in a single group testing session.

Results and Discussion

As anticipated, the Beck Depression Inventory correlated significantly with both subscales of the Mood Survey ($r = .47$, $df = 88$, $p < .001$ for Level; $r = .47$, $df = 88$, $p < .001$ for Reactivity). It seems that scores on this common measure of pathological depression are in fact related to both mood level and mood reactivity, and related about equally strongly. However, the meaning of this pattern of results is once more

obscured by the significant correlation between Level and Reactivity subscales, so partial correlations were computed for BDI scores and each mood subscale, while controlling for the other subscale. BDI scores had significant partial correlations with both Level ($r = -.34$, $df = 87$, $p < .005$) and Reactivity ($r = .27$, $df = 87$, $p < .01$) subscales using these procedures. Consequently, neither subscale can be said to be related to the BDI solely by virtue of its relation to the other subscale; rather, both subscales make a significant, independent contribution to predicting BDI scores. This provides further support for the notion that reactive depression may be as dependent upon mood reactivity as upon mood level.

The Mood Survey, then, has been shown to have factorial unity, reliability over time, concurrent validity, and a stronger relationship to personality measures than a commonly used state measure of mood level. It also provides information about mood reactivity not provided by state measures of mood, information which may play a crucial role in future attempts to use the Mood Survey both for subject selection and to analyze the nature of depressive reactions. Given these facts, we believe the Mood Survey has demonstrated sufficient utility to justify its use in place of the commonly used state measures of mood in certain situations.

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